

Amazon Lex

Amazon offers a service that allows you to build conversational interfaces into your applications using voice and text. This service, named ‘Amazon Lex’, uses the same deep learning engine that powers the now popular Amazon Alexa so that developers can leverage the full potential of the powerful engine for their own use case. Amazon Lex provides both natural language understanding (NLU) and automatic speech recognition (ASR) to enable easy development of highly engaging applications that can have almost lifelike conversations.

Getting Started with Amazon Lex

To start creating your first bot on Lex, navigate to the ‘Services’ tab and then go to Amazon Lex under it. Click on the ‘Create’ button under the list of bots.

A wizard opens up that lets you select either a template or a blank bot schema where you add the bot name. Let us select the ‘OrderFlowers’ bot template that creates a sample bot that can be used to accept orders for flowers. A list of sample sentences called ‘utterances’ would be populated for your bot such as “I would like to order flowers” or “I want to order some flowers”. These are sentences that would invoke the chat bot. You do not need to explicitly map all possible utterances, as amazon uses machine learning to effectively deduce the meaning of your sentence and tries to map it to one of the utterances. These utterances then fire a set of events known as Intents. Intents control the flow of application logic and choose the type of programming logic to execute for a given utterance. Additionally, an utterance might also contain slots that take in user data for processing, such as ‘I would like to order some roses’ would map to an utterance that contains a slot for the last word so that the application knows what kind of flowers the user is trying to order. The bot can also guide the user to add inputs using a series of sentences known as ‘prompts’. An example of a prompt would be “What kind of flowers would you like to order?”

Once all the required data is collected, a bot can fire one or more ‘Confirmation prompts’ that are sentences that let the user



Build your own chat bot with Amazon Lex.